



parties refusing to accept defeat at the polls.

When India entered the era of coalition governments, there were plenty of people who said it could only be held together by strong one party governments. The economic reforms, which at last broke the stranglehold of the "licence permit raj", and freed the creative energies of so many Indian entrepreneurs, were introduced by a government which on paper looked very weak. The destruction of the mosque in Ayodhya was seen by many in India and abroad as the end of Indian secularism and the beginning of religious strife which would turn the country into a Lebanon or a Northern Ireland. But that was nearly 15 years ago now and India is still a secular country. Gujarat in 2002 can now be seen as another aberration, a serious one too but not one that has threatened the unity of India.

All this is not to say that Gujarat or Ayodhya should be dismissed lightly. I have always felt that India is like a great ocean liner which sometimes gets tossed about by mighty storms and tempestuous seas, and seems on the verge of capsizing, but somehow always rights herself and goes on her way. Perhaps as a result of this, there seems to be a widespread belief that India can ride out of any storm, and so no one bothers to take protections even when the black clouds are building up. India remains committed to the "*chalne do*" philosophy. For me one of the most striking examples of this attitude is the failure of successive governments to take stern action against those who threaten secularism by propagating hatred of religions other than their own.

What is it that holds India together? It could be the very fact that has led many of those Jeremiahs to prophesy that it will disintegrate—its size and in particular its diversity. I remember once suggesting to Indira Gandhi that it must be very difficult to govern a country as large and as diverse as India and she replied, "I think it would be much harder to govern a smaller country." She then went on to explain how India's diversity was its strength. "When there is trouble in Bengal", she explained, "the rest of the country just gets on with life as usual, and even when there is trouble in the capital Delhi, it doesn't have a pan-Indian impact." Of course, there have been times, such as the riots after Ayodhya, when the trouble spread well beyond one state, but even then the riots did not engulf the whole of India.

Indira Gandhi's remarks reminded me of a broadcast by Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto at the start of the movement against him in 1977. Speaking with even more than his usual emotion, he said he knew that his opponents would get someone killed in police firing in Lahore and take the body

through the *bazaar*, do the same in Karachi, and so set the whole country on fire. Banging the arms of his chair he said "But this chair is strong, this chair is strong, and I will not allow it to happen." The prime minister's chair was not strong enough and Bhutto was dethroned. That is the problem of a smaller country.

Armies, institutions which are meant to defend their countries from external enemies, often become the enemies of their own people. On the pretext of restoring stability they destabilise their countries. India has been singularly fortunate in having an apolitical army which has never threatened the civilian government. The

PEOPLE'S RAJ:
The finality of the voters' verdict is the hallmark of our democracy



Mandar Deodhar

One of the greatest strengths of India is that the Hindu majority still lives together, peacefully for the most part, with the world's second largest Muslim population.

army must be given full credit for maintaining high standards of discipline which ensure that it obeys whatever orders it is given by the government. We must also give credit to politicians for not trying to persuade the army to intervene on their behalf. But there is another factor too which militates against the army attempting to take power, and it is once again India's diversity. The army is a reflection of that diversity with officers and soldiers coming from all parts of the country. In such a diverse army it would be difficult for any one officer, no matter how senior, or any group of officers, to persuade the whole army to break its disciplined tradition and overthrow the civilian government.